

Pre-hire memo — VP Sales

Sample of what Spine produces on a senior hire before the offer is extended. One page, framework-driven, decision-ready in ten minutes for CEO and sponsor.

ROLE

VP Sales — first GTM leader

COMPANY STAGE

\$30M ARR · Series C SaaS · ~280 FTE

SPONSOR

CEO · founding team

STAKE

Compounds 18mo of GTM, or replaced at day 90

Context. The company has scaled to \$30M ARR through a product-led motion and direct founder selling. The next leg requires a sales-led enterprise motion: \$100k+ ACV, multi-stakeholder cycles, and a small AE bench hired against a defined ICP. The CEO has decided to step out of deal-running and bring in a first VP Sales. The hire either compounds the next eighteen months of pipeline or it costs them.

The candidate. VP Sales at a \$90M ARR SaaS scaleup for the last four years; joined at \$40M, owned expansion into mid-market enterprise. Prior: Head of Sales at a \$8M→\$35M B2B fintech. Strong network, well-regarded by reference operators in the same vintage. Asking compensation in the upper quartile for the role's stage.

Risk concentration. The candidate has not personally owned the founding-team motion — first five AEs, founder-led customer-zero closes, sub-\$50k ACV discipline. Their track record is dominated by mid-stage expansion (replicating an existing motion) rather than zero-to-replicable. The company is asking for the latter. This is the single largest predictor of mis-fit at this stage; literature and Spine's own matched-pair data both flag it. Stage-shape mismatch, not sector or skill.

Reference blind spots. Three of five references describe a hands-off, dashboards-and-weekly-1:1s operating style. None describe IC-level deal-closing or live-coaching of AEs in their first quarter. One reference cites that the prior company "would have benefited from earlier hands-on AE coverage." References were strong on metrics-discipline and expansion playbooks; thin on the founding-stage discipline this role requires.

A-PLAYER PROBABILITY — THIS ROLE · THIS STAGE**38–52%**

Recommendation. Do not extend until the founding-stage discipline has been observed live. At second-round, run a stage-fit case (build the motion from the first five enterprise deals; the candidate, not the AEs, closes them). Probe references specifically for hands-on coaching and IC-deal experience in their last two seats. If extending, structure a six-month milestone — "ship five enterprise deals personally before hiring AE #1" — and a written keep-or-replace decision at day 90 against agreed criteria.